Online appendix to "When disclosure dates and prices diverge: Evidence from the Funeral Rule"

Taylor J. Canann

Online appendix

A.1. Data, audit and sample construction

The Greater Austin panel is read from the FCACTX survey publications for 2013–2024 (there was no 2025 survey; the 2026 wave is not used). Prices and effective dates are taken from the published tables with layout-preserving rules, and unresolved values stay missing. Establishments are linked across waves by telephone number. A two-year link compares survey $t-2$ with survey t for the same establishment, whether or not $t-1$ is observed, using the same rules as the annual links.

The 45 intervals initially flagged as same-date repricing were checked against the current- and preceding-year survey pages. Four price-row alignment errors and one date-parsing error removed five false flags; one real change became ineligible under the two-comparable-measure rule; and correcting a preceding date moved one adjacent interval into the same-date category, giving $45-4-1-1+1=40$. Ten randomly selected final flags (seed 20260907) and two targeted cases were then rechecked. All twelve kept their flag; one required a price-level correction (Gabriels Funeral Chapel, 2014). The audit verifies consistency with the survey pages, not with every underlying provider document.

Of 435 date-defined consecutive intervals, 87 lack two comparable headline prices. Setting every missing new-date outcome to no repricing and every missing same-date outcome to repricing gives a lower bound on the gap of $197/300 - 53/135 = 0.264$. The bound does not address records without a usable date.

Kansas City comparisons use FCA-GKC's 2018, 2020 and 2023 publications, which report month-level GPL dates. Branches are linked across publications, and records that the 2020 publication marks as retained from 2018 are excluded at either endpoint. Because dates are month–year fields, an unchanged month is not necessarily an unchanged day, and inclusion of the crematory fee in the 2018 direct-cremation measure is not explicitly established.

A.2. The date signal by price measure and observation gap

Table A1 scores the date against each price separately. For the basic-services fee, a single GPL line, the date is almost perfectly sensitive (0.980): the fee changed without a new date in 2 of 112 links. Its specificity is low (0.493) because most new lists leave the fee unchanged. The two bundle prices change under an unchanged date more often (28 of 127 for direct cremation and 22 of 119 for burial). Over two-year links, few dates stay unchanged, so sensitivity rises and specificity falls. The date has also become more informative over time: J is 0.492 for intervals ending in 2014–2019 and 0.680 for 2020–2024.

Table A1: Date signal by price measure and observation gap.

Price measure, links	N	New date	Same date	Sens.	Spec.	J
Basic-services fee, annual	323	98/211 (46.4)	2/112 (1.8)	0.980	0.493	0.473
Direct cremation, annual	379	165/252 (65.5)	28/127 (22.0)	0.855	0.532	0.387
Burial incl. casket, annual	341	159/222 (71.6)	22/119 (18.5)	0.878	0.606	0.485
Any of three (main sample), annual	348	197/226 (87.2)	40/122 (32.8)	0.831	0.739	0.570
Direct cremation, two-year links	355	233/299 (77.9)	17/56 (30.4)	0.932	0.371	0.303
Any of three, two-year links	325	255/271 (94.1)	20/54 (37.0)	0.927	0.680	0.607
Kansas City, cremation, 2018–20	81	37/59 (62.7)	1/22 (4.5)	0.974	0.488	0.462
Kansas City, cremation, 2020–23	75	54/68 (79.4)	1/7 (14.3)	0.982	0.300	0.282

Notes: Repriced/links (%) for new-date and same-date links. Single-measure rows use every link at which that price is comparable, so samples differ from the main sample. Two-year links compare survey $t-2$ with t. Kansas City rows use month-level dates from published FCA-GKC survey tables and exclude records marked as carried forward.

A.3. Same-date changes and survey noise

Table A2 compares same-date and new-date price changes on two symptoms of recording noise: decreases, and reversal to the earlier price in the following year. Same-date changes show more of both, and almost all of the excess is in the burial measure, whose least-expensive casket is priced on a separately dated casket price list. Removing every reversed change leaves the result in the main text. If changes whose next-year price is unobserved are also dropped, the rates are 149/181 (82.3%) and 27/114 (23.7%), with $J = 0.578$. Same-date repricing occurs at 16 establishments, and none accounts for more than 15% of the 40 intervals.

Table A2: Do same-date price changes look like survey noise?

	Same date			New date		
Component	Changes	Decreases	Reversed	Changes	Decreases	Reversed
Direct cremation	26	6	1/20	153	22	4/125
Burial incl. casket	22	12	5/19	159	22	5/124
Basic-services fee	1	0	0/1	91	11	3/66
All	49	18	6/40	403	55	12/315

Notes: Changed component events (more than \$5) in the 348 annual intervals. Reversed: the price at $t+1$ is within \$5 of its value at $t-1$, among events whose next-year price is observed. Fisher exact p-values for same- versus new-date differences: decreases < 0.001, reversals 0.009.

A.4. Robustness of the repricing gap

Table A3 collects alternative samples, thresholds and exclusions. Except for the worst-case missing-data bound (0.264), the gap between new-date and same-date repricing stays between 0.502 and 0.652, and no single brand or establishment drives it.

Table A3: Robustness of the same-date versus new-date repricing gap, Greater Austin.

Check	New date	Same date	Gap
Baseline	197/226 (87.2)	40/122 (32.8)	0.544
All three prices observed	167/191 (87.4)	36/106 (34.0)	0.535
Cremation or fee only (burial dropped)	147/195 (75.4)	25/109 (22.9)	0.524
Both surveys 2019 or later	74/82 (90.2)	13/52 (25.0)	0.652
Omit 2016–2017 survey redesign	178/203 (87.7)	34/110 (30.9)	0.568
Omit website/phone-sourced flags	197/226 (87.2)	37/119 (31.1)	0.561
Omit two audited histories	189/217 (87.1)	34/109 (31.2)	0.559
Threshold \$25	194/226 (85.8)	40/122 (32.8)	0.531
Threshold 2.5%	182/226 (80.5)	35/122 (28.7)	0.518
Threshold 5%	158/226 (69.9)	24/122 (19.7)	0.502
Drop changes reversed next year	194/226 (85.8)	35/122 (28.7)	0.572
Worst-case missing price outcomes			0.264
Leave one coded brand out (range)			0.524–0.560
Leave one establishment out (range)			0.523–0.572

Notes: Repriced/intervals (%). Rows other than the last four and the reversal row reproduce the replication package's robustness outputs. Worst case: every missing new-date outcome set to no repricing and every missing same-date outcome to repricing. "Drop changes reversed next year" keeps changes whose next-year price is unobserved.

A.5. Prior list age: additional specifications and simulation

Table A4 splits the price regression by date status and repeats both regressions on the sample at which direct cremation and the fee are comparable, where the date and price gradients are close. Table A5 reports the simulation described in the main text. With establishment effects, list age predicts a date change even though the simulated hazard is constant, because age resets when the date changes and the within transformation uses each provider's own average date-change rate. Without establishment effects, providers that rarely re-date both hold older lists and re-date less, which produces a negative coefficient.

Table A4: Prior list age: additional specifications.

Outcome and sample	Coefficient on prior list age	N
Price change, same-date intervals only	0.015 (0.043) [0.826]	122
Price change, new-date intervals only	−0.007 (0.025) [0.755]	226
Date change, cremation/fee sample	0.082 (0.041) [0.049]	304
Cremation or fee change, cremation/fee sample	0.065 (0.037) [0.076]	304
Date minus price change, establishment and year effects	0.044 (0.039) [0.285]	348
Date minus price change, year effects only	−0.069 (0.023) [0.030]	348

Notes: Linear probability models. The first five rows include establishment and year effects. Establishment-clustered standard errors in parentheses; wild-cluster bootstrap p-values (4,999 Rademacher draws) in brackets. The cremation/fee sample is the 304 intervals at which both direct cremation and the basic-services fee are comparable. "Date minus price" regresses $D - R$ on age and tests whether the two gradients are equal.

Table A5: List-age coefficients when the true hazard is constant.

Simulated process	Establishment and year effects	Year effects only
Homogeneous hazard, $p = 0.65$	0.091 (0.027)	0.003 (0.024)
Heterogeneous, Beta(2.6, 1.4)	0.076 (0.023)	−0.068 (0.021)
More heterogeneous, Beta(1.3, 0.7)	0.063 (0.020)	−0.101 (0.015)
Austin estimate, Table 2 column (1)	0.088	−0.076

Notes: Mean (standard deviation) of the coefficient on prior list age in a regression of the date-change indicator, over 500 simulated panels of 53 providers and seven annual intervals. Each provider re-dates with a constant probability drawn as shown (mean 0.65, matching Austin's 64.9% date-change frequency), so there is no duration dependence. Initial list age is uniform on $[0, 3]$ years; a list issued during an interval is uniform on $[0, 1]$ years old at the next survey; otherwise age rises by one year.